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The New York Times



Zucel Guerra Brise, center, lining up to buy rolls that she will resell for a tiny profit to help support her family in Santiago de Cuba.

Politics Color Race to Supply Navy Drones

By KATE KELLY and JULIE TATE

WASHINGTON — The dramatic sea rescue of two stranded military aviators last month near the Strait of Hormuz was a demonstration of why the Navy sees drone boats as promising new technology.

On June 8, the Navy rushed in an unmanned vessel called a Corsair to pick up the pilots, whose helicopter had been downed by a drone explosion nearby, zipping them to safety without risking other lives.

“Autonomous systems changed the lives of several pilots and their families forever,” Rebecca Gassler, the Navy portfolio acquisition executive running robotics and autonomous systems, said at an industry event the next day.

Back in the United States, though, a clash was erupting over which companies would get access to the huge sums the Pentagon is throwing at emerging technologies.

As warfare is being transformed by rapid advances in drones, artificial intelligence and other fields, the Defense Department is trying to adapt by developing the equipment that it needs faster and more efficiently. It is a push that many defense contractors and the military believe is long overdue.

But the shift has ignited a furious competition within a new generation of military contractors. The contest to build advanced drone boats for the Navy is a vivid example of how those firms are scrambling for advantage, spawning accusations of contracting violations and political favoritism along the way.

At stake are chunks of the \$2.1 billion that Congress set aside last year to fund a new fleet of medium-size autonomous Navy vessels.

Over the past year, the Navy asked vendors for proposals, announced the winners, then scrapped the process and started anew.

On May 29, the Navy announced a winnowed list of seven vendors under consideration to build the larger cousin to the Corsair.

Some of those selected, including Saronic Technologies, the maker of the Corsair, had ties to President Trump, his family or his

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NATIONAL A11-20

A MAHA Priority Loses Out

An official urged requiring a fish farm to monitor for tiny plastic particles. The E.P.A. fired him.

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Trump Tries to Rewrite Rules

The president is using many levers to try to reshape the rules governing the midterms and future elections.

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How a Cuban Family Survives on \$60 a Month

By ED AUGUSTIN

SANTIAGO DE CUBA — Adrián Silva Guerra saw the streetlight flicker back to life. It was 2:08 a.m. on a Thursday. An electric repairman, Mr. Silva Guerra quickly got up from his concrete stoop and went inside, leaving the front door ajar so the night air would drift over his 7-year-old son sleeping on a foam mattress.

He walked into his workshop, sat down next to a stack of broken televisions he cannibalizes for spare parts and began to solder. A ribbon of smoke wafted from a green-and-copper circuit board he was working on to repair a televi-

When All Else Fails, Relying on Solidarity in an Oil Blockade

sion. He did as much as he could until, two hours later, he was plunged back into darkness.

“I’m a slave to the current,” said Mr. Silva Guerra, 32, haggard and sleep deprived.

Shortly before the lights went out, his mother, Zucel Guerra Brise, 52, left their house here in Cuba’s second-largest city, along the country’s southeastern coast. Thanks to the trickle of electricity,

the ovens at a local privately owned bakery made bread that night.

She lined up to buy 100 small rolls of bread, preparing to walk the city’s streets and resell them so her family would have money for lunch. She paid 7 cents per roll and sold each for 9 cents.

Mr. Silva Guerra; his mother; and his father, Luis Silva Aldana, 64, a primary-school teacher, cobble together the equivalent of less than \$60 a month. With this they must sustain their four-generation family, which includes Mr. Silva Guerra’s wife, Analeidis Arias Matos, their two young children and Zoe, his grandmother.

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Clash of Continental Powers

Spain defeated France, 2-0, in a star-studded World Cup semifinal. Coverage at nytimes.com.

Undocumented, Chasing a Dream and Shot Dead

By EDGAR SANDOVAL and JAZMINE ULLOA

HOUSTON — Lorenzo Salgado Araujo’s journey began southwest of Mexico City, in rural San Antonio del Rosario, where he was the ninth of 12 children.

It was Mr. Salgado Araujo’s brother Julian, the fourth born, who first felt the pull of America, he said in an interview with The New York Times. So Julian made his way north to the border some-

The Decades-Long Trek of a Houston Worker

time in the 1980s, he said. Wading across the Tijuana River, he entered the United States illegally and eventually made his way to Los Angeles.

A few years later, when Lorenzo was about 17, he followed, crossing the border illegally and eventu-

ally finding work in construction in Houston, where he built a business and where, his family said, he had been seeking to put himself on a path to legal status.

On July 7, Mr. Salgado Araujo, 52, headed to work as he would any other day, wearing a baseball

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TRAFFIC STOPS ICE has been ordered to halt most stops after two killings in a week. PAGE A19

Inflation Falls, But Iran War Risks Relapse

Oil Prices Set to Climb, Renewing Pressure

By TONY ROMM

WASHINGTON — When rising gas prices began to cut into Americans’ paychecks, President Trump’s top economic adviser sought to offer a note of reassurance — both for struggling families and for his increasingly nervous political party.

It was late April, about two months into the war with Iran, but Kevin Hassett, the director of the National Economic Council, argued that Americans were actually in strong financial shape. And as a result, he added, the gains in the economy seemed poised to boost Republicans’ political prospects in time for the November midterms.

“People look at their wallets, and they vote,” Mr. Hassett told reporters that day, citing “massive economic literature that says that that’s how you predict elections.”

The first summer report card, which arrived on Tuesday, offered an early bit of positive news for the White House: Consumer prices fell 0.4 percent in June. It was a notable improvement from the three-year high registered in May, even though prices overall were up 3.5 percent compared to the same time last year, a rate still well above policymakers’ 2 percent target.

But the report arrived precisely as the United States and Iran returned to open conflict, threatening to reignite the very sort of economic chaos that had caused inflation to soar to a three-year high in the first place. By Tuesday morning, oil and gas prices seemed poised to climb, raising the odds that a recent reprieve at the pump could prove short lived, squeezing families and businesses once again in the coming months.

The split-screen developments seemed to perfectly frame the political stakes for Mr. Trump, as he races against the clock to assuage voters who increasingly blame the White House for their financial strain. A significant and prolonged escalation in the war could erase recent progress on inflation, angering the public and forcing the Federal Reserve to raise interest rates, a move that could further saddle families with new expenses.

Despite those mounting risks,

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ON A BREAK The Consumer Price Index fell in June amid a pause in fighting against Iran. PAGE B1

THE WEATHER

Today, hazy sunshine, afternoon thunderstorm, high 98, feeling like over 100. **Tonight**, thunderstorm, low 75. **Tomorrow**, less humid, high 92. Weather map is on Page A24.

STRIKES ESCALATE, AS PLAN TO LEVY TOLL IS REVERSED

STRAIT TRAFFIC DROPS

Global Economic Risks as U.S. Navy Prepares to Restart Blockade

This article is by Max Bearak, Jenny Gross and Michael Levenson.

The U.S. military bombed more Iranian targets on Tuesday, returning to the kind of intensive attacks that marked the start of the war, as President Trump abruptly dropped a plan he had announced a day earlier to charge shipping companies fees for providing security in the Strait of Hormuz.

As the two countries have sharply increased their attacks over the past week, the truce they signed last month has been left in tatters, and Mr. Trump’s path out of the conflict remained unclear. Both sides are seeking to control the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial transit route for oil and gas shipments. The renewed hostilities have severely curtailed sea and air traffic to the region with consequences for the global economy.

On Monday, Mr. Trump said he had decided to impose a 20 percent fee on cargo passing through the strait to reimburse the U.S. military for providing security. Analysts said the plan could have more than doubled the cost of shipping oil through the strait, driving up global energy prices. Vice President JD Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio had also spent months declaring the administration was opposed to fees or tolls in international waterways.

On Tuesday, Mr. Trump reversed course, scrapping the fee plan, in the latest dizzying shift in his Iran policy.

He said he had decided not to impose fees after the leaders of Persian Gulf nations — “kings and emirs, and all of the people that we

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DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump’s toll flip is the latest shift in his Iran policy.

Emails Reveal Blanche’s Role In Trump’s Drive for Revenge

By GLENN THRUSH

WASHINGTON — Todd Blanche, then the Justice Department’s No. 2 official, had been on the job only for a couple of months in May 2025, when he was handed a migraine in a Detective Columbo trench coat by the name of Edward J. Martin Jr.

Mr. Martin, a right-wing lawyer who championed the cause of the Jan. 6 rioters, had just been forced out as the acting U.S. attorney for the District of Columbia. The White House then inserted him into Justice Department headquarters, in part to oversee a task force to investigate claims that the Biden administration had targeted President Trump and his allies.

Mr. Blanche, who once led Mr. Trump’s criminal defense team, did not believe that Mr. Martin, a provocateur with minimal prosecutorial experience, had the

chops and know-how to do the job, according to current and former officials who requested anonymity to discuss private conversations.

“I am frustrated,” Mr. Blanche wrote to Mr. Martin, after less than a month on the job, documenting a relationship that swiftly descended from tense to testy.

He moved quickly to rein in Mr. Martin, scheduling a check-in meeting every Friday, according to a trove of internal Justice Department emails obtained by a government watchdog and provided to The New York Times in advance of Mr. Blanche’s confirmation hearing to be attorney general on Wednesday.

Mr. Blanche, a methodical former federal prosecutor, also created an organizational plan for the

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SPORTS B6-9

A Change for the Tougher

A trip around a remodeled Royal Birkdale course suggested that competitors in the British Open, which starts on Thursday, would be tested.

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OBITUARIES B10-11

Helpers of the Homeless

Jayson Conner, 48, and Jeffrey Newman, 58, who died a few days apart, gave backpacks filled with supplies to people on New York’s streets. PAGE B10

OPINION A22-23

Michelle Goldberg

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A Storied Venue Reopens

With Lizzo and a calm flair, the gorgeously renovated Hunter Pavilion at Ravinia was inaugurated.

PAGE C1

Empty Seats at Smithsonian

An odd silence has surrounded a delay to fill several vacancies on the board of an institution under siege.

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INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Rebuilding Japan’s Spy Agency

Facing threats from Russia and China, Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is turning to help from Western allies in forming a centralized bureau.

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BUSINESS B1-5

A.I. Copycats Catching Up

U.S. companies complain that competitors in China are unfairly mining their artificial-intelligence systems.

PAGE B1

Bloomberg Loses in Libel Trial

A judge ruled that the news agency and a reporter had defamed two Singapore government ministers.

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FOOD D1-8

Best of the Burgers

From Scotch bonnet chiles to pork belly to gochugaru, what dynamic New York eateries are putting between two buns (or maybe no bun).

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